In June 2013, Edward Snowden, a former employee of the National Security Agency, leaked secret information about the agency. There were thousands of classified information that Snowden leaked to the public. These include classified programs like PRISM, Bulk Data Collection, XKeyscore, and Boundless Informant. He used to work as a system administrator, senior adviser, and solution consultant in intelligence agencies like the CIA, and the NSA. Snowden, in these types of positions, was allowed to see more classified information than he normally would as a normal employee of these agencies. He claimed that when he talked about these privacy rights the agencies had been breaking to his friends and family and people around him, these people did not take it seriously and would rather ignore them and continue their daily lives. As time passed, he started to realize that these are things that should be exposed to the public that these government intelligence agencies had been doing across privacy rights. This paper will cover some of the overviews of what Edward Snowden exposed of the NSA secret programs and the United States' privacy vs security through the past few decades along with opinions.

PRISM is a project revealed to the public by Edward Snowden that the National Security Agency tracks users' internet data from large tech companies like Google LLC, Apple Inc., and Meta Platforms, Inc. (formerly Facebook Inc.) and internet providers. These companies had to pay for the information that the NSA asked for under the law of the FISA Amendments Act, Section 702. This also affects the encrypted data through the internet meaning the companies must decrypt the data if the NSA needs them. The project was activated in 2007 under the control of President Bush, mainly to control terrorism and to maintain national security. The NSA not only tracks these data but also stores them on their servers for a certain period.

Snowden leaked another project the NSA had been doing on the public which is Bulk Data Collection. It mainly collects metadata within the NSA servers that Americans talk on their mobile phone every day but the agency claimed that they did not collect context inside the communications but the information such as duration, numbers, and device identity. They collect this information for the same reason as the PRISM project. The project operated under Section 215 of the PATRIOT Act after the September 11 attack.

Another project revealed by Snowden was XKeyscore which mainly tracks internet data and stores them. These are generally emails, chats, and other telecommunications via the internet. This program is targeted globally to protect terrorism from foreign countries against the United States threatening national security. The NSA then viewed these massive amounts of data with a graphical visualizing tool called Boundless Informant. Boundless Informant displays all the data collected domestically and internationally with a clear view so that the agency can know if there are any suspicious activities.

Throughout the history of the United States, privacy has not been respected under the influence of national security. The civilians were being tracked by the intelligence agencies digitally. But, from time to time, privacy has been respected and organizations like the Church Committee and people like Edward Snowden have revealed the actions of these agencies to the public. This way, it can be said that people nowadays have more privacy compared to those 50 years ago.